something of a success: at the end of the eight rounds, neither side was left with illusions about the other's stand. The reason for their relative success is that they were held away from the public gaze: unlike in 1960, when the Nehru government and then China made the mistake of publishing the bilateral correspondence, the substance of the dialogue was kept relatively secret.[91]

What was achieved? First of all, India was able to abandon its insistence that a settlement of the border must precede the full normalization of relations. After 1962, India had insisted that it would not resume normal relations with China until the border was settled. New Delhi finally agreed to separate the resumption of economic and other interactions from progress on the border. This volte face became public during Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi's December 1988 visit to Beijing. Secondly, the two sides agreed that they would adopt the view that 'until everything is agreed, nothing is agreed'. This meant India and China would have to agree sector by sector and then further agree that all the sectoral agreements were acceptable in order for any sector to be finally settled. Thirdly, and most importantly, both sides finally abandoned the idea of the swap. Since 1962, Delhi had assumed that China's claims south of the McMahon Line were limited and the main claims were in the western sector. The swap offers right up to 1983 lent weight to the interpretation that above all Beijing wanted to ensure the security of its road from Xinjiang to Tibet. At the sixth round of the talks, China changed its stand completely, arguing that the eastern sector was more important than the western sector and that India would have to make concessions in the east if it wanted a settlement in the west.

Why did China abandon the idea of a swap, and why did it change its view of the relative importance of the two sectors? It is hard to know exactly, but Beijing must have concluded that it was wasting its time on the swap. After the first round of the negotiations, India's Foreign Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao had categorically rejected the swap in his statement in Parliament: 'The government of India has never accepted the premise on which it is based, namely, that the Chinese side is making a concession in the eastern sector by giving up of territory which they allege is illegally